In January 2002, President Pervez Musharraf took two important steps toward deescalating the crisis. First, he outlawed Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed. Then, in a nationally televised speech on January 12, he pledged to prevent Pakistani territory from being used to foment terrorism in Kashmir. U.S. secretary of state Colin Powell, visiting New Delhi after stopping in Islamabad, subsequently assured Indian leaders that Musharraf was working to reduce terrorism and was actively contemplating the extradition of non-Pakistanis who were on India's list of twenty fugitives.[79] In the wake of Powell's visit, the Indians decided not to attack Pakistan.[80] However, Indian forces remained deployed along the LOC and international border.

The second phase of the 2001–2002 crisis erupted on May 14, 2002, when terrorists killed thirty-two people at an Indian army camp at Kaluchak in Jammu.[81] Outraged Indian leaders formulated a military response considerably more ambitious than the plans adopted in January. Now, rather than simply attacking across the LOC, the Indians planned to drive three strike corps from Rajasthan into Pakistan, engaging and destroying Pakistani forces and seizing territory in the Thar Desert. Before the Indians could act, however, the United States once again intervened. In early June, U.S. deputy secretary of state Richard Armitage extracted a promise from president Musharraf not just to reduce militant infiltration into Indian Kashmir, but to end infiltration "permanently." Armitage conveyed Musharraf's pledge to Indian officials, who subsequently decided not to attack Pakistan and to bring Operation Parakram to a close. Indian forces began withdrawing from the international border and LOC in October.

Why did India demobilize without attacking Pakistan? Did nuclear weapons play a role in persuading Indian leaders to back down during the 2001–2002 crisis?

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Repeated and timely American interventions throughout the course of this crisis are frequently cited as the principal reasons for the